Fix Delivery Drag

A practical guide for product and engineering teams

Outcome

Find what is slowing delivery and fix it within two weeks.

Diagnose

See where work is getting stuck.

Decide

Choose one next move.

Execute

Move with a practical plan.

One-page summary

Find what is slowing delivery and fix it within two weeks. This guide gives you a practical path from uncertainty to action.

- Best for: Product and Engineering
- Topic: Delivery
- Read this first, then jump to the section that matches your pressure.
- Use one page at a time during real team decisions.

When to use

Use this playbook when these conditions start showing up in your team.

- Delivery is slowing down and people disagree on the reason.
- The team is busy every day, but outcomes still feel weak.
- Work keeps starting and stalling before it ships.
- Priorities change faster than plans can adapt.

Symptoms checklist

Check everything that feels true right now.

- [ ] Cycle time is drifting up every sprint.
- [ ] Dependencies are discovered too late.
- [ ] High-priority work jumps the queue every week.
- [ ] Review and QA become recurring bottlenecks.
- [ ] Roadmaps keep changing but confidence stays low.

Decision framework

Use these four lenses together. If one lens is weak, the decision usually gets risky fast.

Observe

Map where work pauses across discovery, build, review, and release.

Isolate

Separate visible symptoms from the true limiting constraint.

Decide

Choose the one fix that unlocks the most progress now.

Reset

Run a two-week reset with clear ownership and check-ins.

Step-by-step approach (part 1)

Use these steps in order. Keep each step simple and observable.

- Map current flow with product and engineering in one room.
- Mark queues, handoffs, and approval waits in plain language.
- Find the longest wait present in most delivery paths.

Step-by-step approach (part 2)

Finish the sequence and confirm what changed before adding more scope.

- Pick one change that reduces that wait within two weeks.
- Set a visible scoreboard for completion, cycle time, and blockers.
- Run one focused reset sprint and review what changed.

Examples

Use examples to pressure-test your assumptions before committing.

- A product squad cut review queues by introducing a 24-hour review SLA.
- A platform team reduced blocked tickets after assigning one dependency owner.
- A fintech team improved release speed by pairing QA earlier in the sprint.

Templates

These templates are designed for working sessions, not slides.

- Delivery drag diagnostic worksheet
- Constraint mapping board template
- Two-week reset planning template
- Weekly unblocker log template

30-day plan

Use this as a practical first month plan.

- Week 1: Diagnose and align on one true constraint.
- Week 2: Run the focused reset and remove top blockers.
- Week 3: Standardize what worked and document ownership.
- Week 4: Review outcomes and set the next operating habit.

Example walkthrough: unstable sprint flow

A team shipped less each sprint even though capacity stayed flat.

- Root cause: work entered sprint without dependency checks.
- Fix: a pre-sprint dependency review with one owner.
- Result: completion rate improved in three weeks.

Example walkthrough: slow approvals

Escalations were caused by unclear approval ownership.

- Root cause: multiple sign-offs, no clear SLA.
- Fix: one accountable approver plus backup delegate.
- Result: lead time dropped by multiple business days.

Template workbook: blocker triage

Use this worksheet during weekly delivery reviews.

- [ ] What is blocked right now?
- [ ] Who owns the unblock action?
- [ ] What decision is needed today?
- [ ] What changes by next review?

Template workbook: dependency map

Keep this map lightweight and current each week.

- Critical dependency by squad
- Expected date and confidence
- Fallback plan if late
- Escalation path

Leadership alignment prompts

Use these prompts to keep the reset focused.

- What is the one behavior we stop this week?
- What is the one decision we make faster?
- Where do we need tighter ownership?
- What should we not change yet?

30-day execution scoreboard

Track a small scorecard every Friday.

- [ ] Cycle time trend
- [ ] Completed vs started work
- [ ] Blocked ticket aging
- [ ] Escalations resolved within 48 hours

Risk watchlist before reset

Document these risks before changing workflow.

- Critical release dates in the next month
- Teams that cannot pause parallel initiatives
- Dependencies outside engineering control
- Compliance constraints that affect timing

Final next step

- Start with one team, one workflow, and one clear metric.
- If the work still feels noisy, we can help you run the first reset with your leads.
- The goal is simple: less chaos, faster delivery, and more confidence.

How Amalgam can help

Founder Review

Get a clear read on what is stuck and what to do next.

Expert Guidance

Unblock one critical path and get delivery moving again.

Outcome Partnership

Stay supported while work ships and priorities keep changing.

See services: amalgam-inc.com/services
Book a strategy call: amalgam-inc.com/contact